

In single-spaced text, you may want to make reading easier by adding extra space between paragraphs, rather than indenting the first lines of paragraphs. This format, referred to as **block style**, is often used in memos, letters, and electronic documents. When creating electronic documents, especially Web pages, you might consider chunking your material into separate “pages” or screens, with links connecting the chunks.

Margins. Adequate margins are an important component of general readability. If the margins are too small, your page will seem cluttered. Generally, for academic essays, use one-inch margins on all sides unless your instructor (or the style manual you are following) advises differently. Some instructors ask students to leave large margins to accommodate marginal comments.

Visuals

Tables, graphs, charts, diagrams, photographs, maps, and screen shots add visual interest and are often more effective in conveying information than prose alone. Be certain, however, that each visual has a valid role to play in your work; if the visual is merely a decoration, leave it out or replace it with a visual that is more appropriate.

You can create visuals on a computer, using the drawing tools of a word processing program, the charting tools of a spreadsheet program, or software specifically designed for creating visuals. You can also download visuals from the Internet or photocopy or scan visuals from print materials. If your essay is going to be posted on the Web on a site that is not password-protected and a visual you want to use is from a source that is copyrighted, you should request written permission from the copyright holder (such as the photographer, publisher, or site sponsor). For any visual that you borrow from or create based on data from a source, be sure to cite the source in the caption, your bibliography, or both, according to the guidelines of the documentation system you are using.

Choose Appropriate Visuals and Design the Visuals with Their Final Use in Mind

Select the types of visuals that will best suit your purpose. The following list identifies various types, explains what they are best used for, and provides examples. If you plan to incorporate a visual into a computer-projected display, try to envision the original version as it would appear enlarged on a screen. Similarly, if you intend the visual for use on a Web page, consider how it will appear when displayed on a computer screen.

- **Tables.** A table is used to display numerical or textual data that is organized into columns and rows to make it easy to understand. A table usually includes several items as well as variables for each item. For example, the first column of Table 21.1 includes cities and states; the next two columns show the city

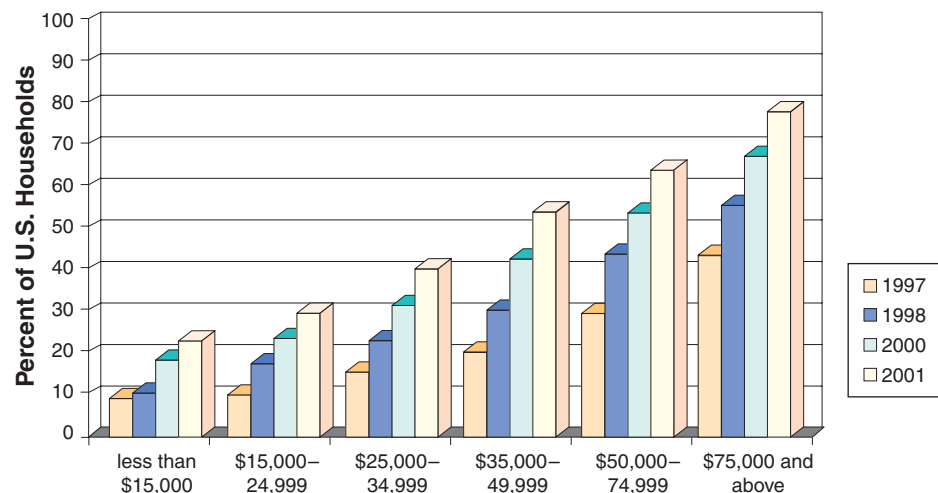
Table 21.1 Population Change for the Ten Largest U.S. Cities, 1990 to 2000

<i>City and State</i>	<i>Population</i>		<i>Change, 1990 to 2000</i>	
	<i>April 1, 2000</i>	<i>April 1, 1990</i>	<i>Number</i>	<i>Percentage</i>
New York, NY	8,008,278	7,322,564	685,714	9.4
Los Angeles, CA	3,694,820	3,485,398	209,422	6.0
Chicago, IL	2,896,016	2,783,726	112,290	4.0
Houston, TX	1,953,631	1,630,553	323,078	19.8
Philadelphia, PA	1,517,550	1,585,577	−68,027	−4.3
Phoenix, AZ	1,321,045	983,403	337,642	34.3
San Diego, CA	1,223,400	1,110,549	112,851	10.2
Dallas, TX	1,188,580	1,006,877	181,703	18.0
San Antonio, TX	1,144,646	935,933	208,713	22.3
Detroit, MI	951,270	1,027,974	−76,704	−7.5

Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Census 2000; 1990 Census, Population and Housing Unit Counts, United States (1990 CPH-2-1).

population in 1990 and in 2000; and the final two columns show the change in population from 1990 to 2000 in number and percentage.

- **Bar graphs.** A bar graph typically compares numerical differences, often over time, for one or more items. For example, Figure 21.3 shows the rise in Internet access across five years (1997–2001) for U.S. households of varying incomes.

**Figure 21.3 Percent of U.S. Households with Internet Access by Income**

Source: U.S. Department of Commerce.

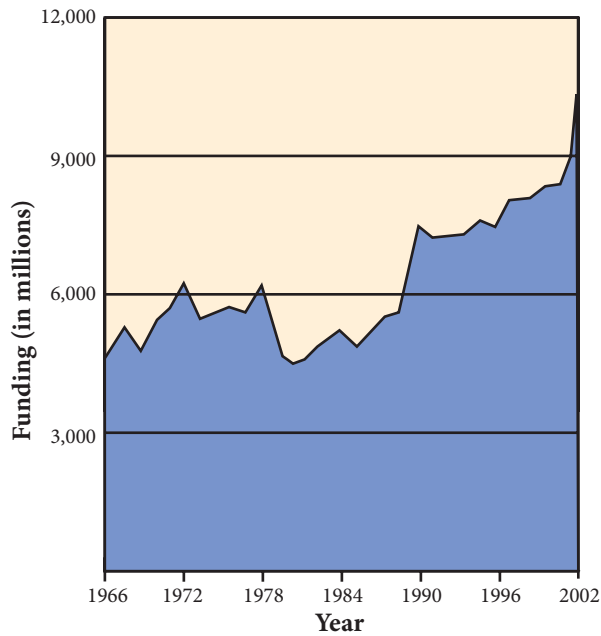


Figure 21.4 Title I Spending for Low-Income Children (in constant dollars)

Source: U.S. Department of Education.

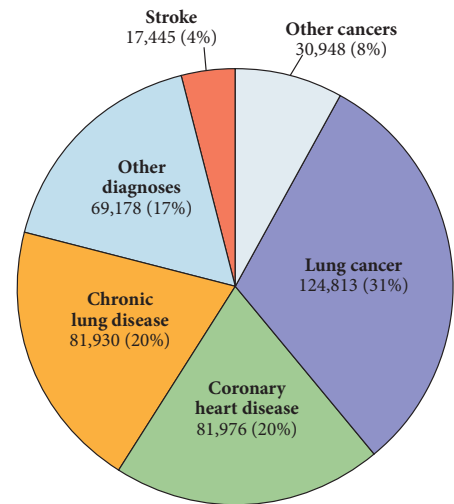


Figure 21.5 Average Annual U.S. Deaths Attributable to Cigarette Smoking, 1995–1999

Source: Data from U.S. Centers for Disease Control.

Note: Total annual average is 406,290 deaths.

- **Line graphs.** A line graph charts change over time, typically with only one variable represented (unlike in Figure 21.3, where the bar chart data are organized into six variables). For example, Figure 21.4 shows the amount of government spending for low-income children between 1966 and 2002.
- **Pie charts.** A pie chart shows the sizes of parts making up a whole. For instance, the whole (100 percent) in the chart shown in Figure 21.5 is the average annual number of deaths in the United States attributable to cigarette smoking; the parts are the specific causes of death, such as lung cancer (31 percent) and coronary heart disease (20 percent).
- **Flowcharts.** A flowchart shows a process broken down into parts or stages. Flowcharts are particularly helpful for explaining a process or facilitating a decision based on a set of circumstances, as shown, for instance, in Figure 21.6.
- **Organization charts.** An organization chart does what its name suggests — it creates a map of lines of authority within an organization, such as a company. Typically, the most important person — the person to whom most employees report — appears at the top of the chart, as seen in Figure 21.7, where the managing editor, who oversees the entire daily newspaper, appears at the top.

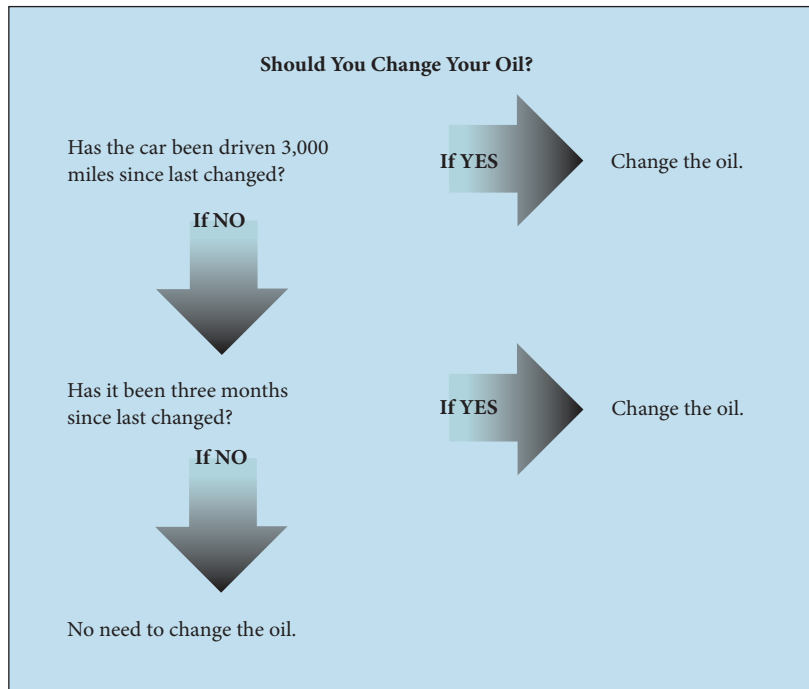


Figure 21.6 Oil-Changing Decision Process

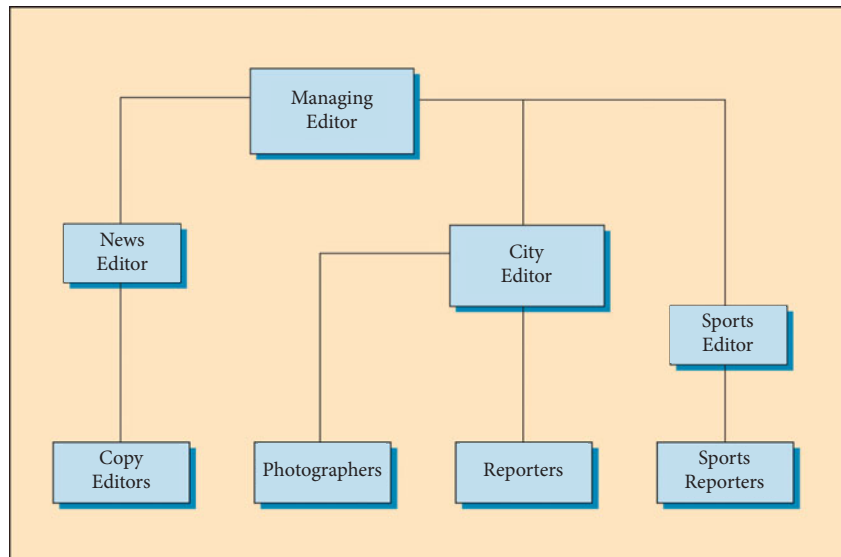


Figure 21.7 The Newsroom of a Typical Small Daily Newspaper

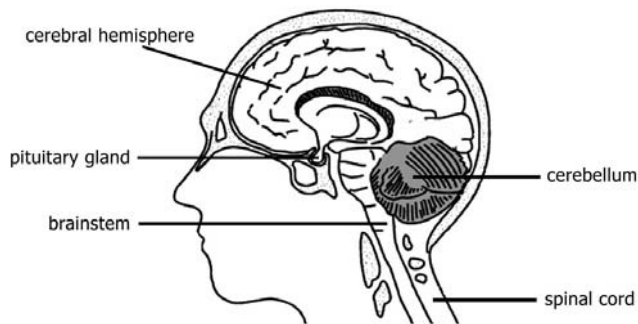


Figure 21.8 A Cross-Section of the Human Brain

- **Diagrams.** A diagram depicts an item or its properties, often using symbols. It is typically used to show relationships or how things function. (See Figure 21.8.)
- **Drawings and cartoons.** A drawing shows a simplified version or an artist's interpretation of an object or situation. Cartoons, like the one in Figure 21.9, are drawings typically used to make an argumentative point, usually in a humorous way.
- **Photographs.** Photographs are used when an author wants to represent a real and specific object, place, or person, often for its emotional impact. For instance, a student selected Figure 21.10, a photo of a burrowing owl, to be included in a report about the ways in which local development was affecting endangered species. Although photographic images are generally assumed to duplicate what the eye sees, a photograph may, in fact, be manipulated in a variety of ways for special effects. Photographs that have been altered should be so identified.



Figure 21.9 A Cartoon That Makes an Argument about Using Native American Names for Sports Teams



Figure 21.10 The Burrowing Owl

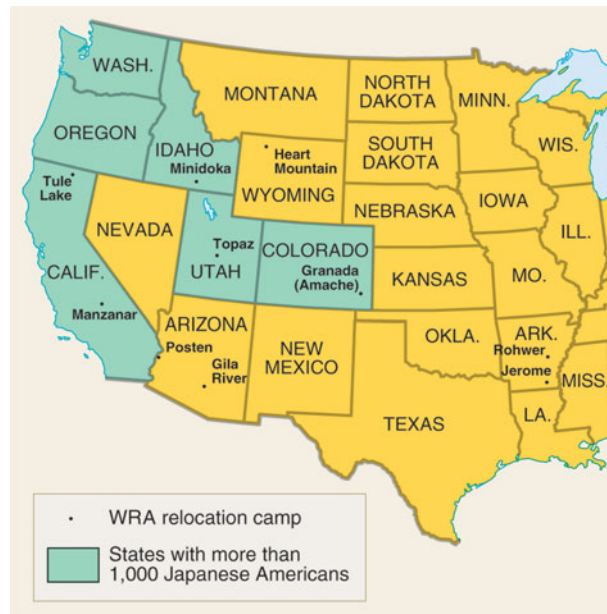


Figure 21.11 Western Relocation Authority Centers

- **Maps.** Maps are used to show geographical areas, lay out the spatial relationships of objects, or make a historical or political point. Figure 21.11 identifies World War II-era Western Relocation Authority Centers and states that had a high Japanese American population during World War II. The map reveals that though they posed no threat to U.S. security, many Japanese Americans were relocated a great distance from their homes during the war.

- **Screen shots.** A screen shot duplicates the appearance of a specific computer screen or of a window or other section within it. Screen shots can be used to capture a Web page to include in a print document or to describe steps or instructions for using a piece of software (see Figure 21.12).

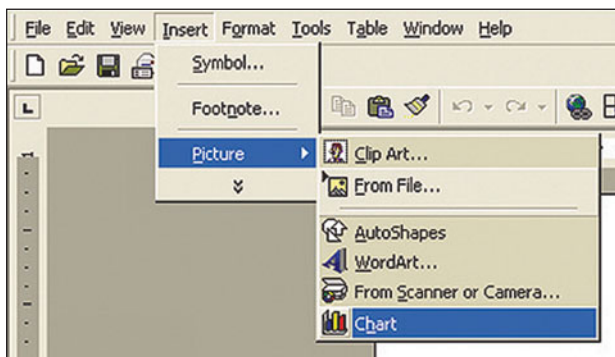


Figure 21.12 Screen Capture to Accompany Written Instructions, “How to Insert a Chart into a Word Processing Document”

Number and Title Your Visuals

Number your visuals in sequential order and give each one a title. Refer to tables as *Table 1*, *Table 2*, and so on, and to other types of visuals as *Figure 1*, *Figure 2*, and so on. (In a long work with chapters or sections, you may also need to include the chapter or section number [*Figure 21.1*], as is done in this chapter of this book.)

Make sure each visual has a title that reflects the subject of the visual (for example, income levels) and its purpose (to compare and illustrate changes in those income levels): *Figure 1. Percentage of U.S. Households in Three Income Ranges, 1990–2000*. Notice that MLA style requires that the title for a table be placed above the table and the title for a figure be placed below the figure.

Label the Parts of Your Visuals and Include Descriptive Captions

To help readers understand a visual, clearly label all of its parts. In a table, for instance, give each column a heading; likewise, label each section of a pie chart with the percentage and the item it represents. You may place the label on the chart itself if it is readable and clear; if that is not practical, place a legend next to the chart.

Some visuals may require a caption that provides a fuller description than the title alone does. Your caption might also include an explanation helpful to understand the visual, as in Figure 21.11.

Cite Your Visual Sources

Finally, if you borrow a visual from another source or create a visual from borrowed information, you must cite the source, following the guidelines for the documentation style you are using (see Figure 21.2 and Table 21.1 for examples). In addition, be sure to document the source in your list of works cited or references at the end of your document.

Integrate the Visual into the Text

Visuals should facilitate, not disrupt, the reading of the body text. To achieve this goal, you need to first introduce and discuss the visual in your text and then insert the visual in an appropriate location.

Introducing the Visual. Ideally, you should introduce each visual by referring to it in your text immediately *before* the visual appears. An effective textual reference answers the following questions:

- What is the number of the visual?
- Where is it located?
- What kind of information does it contain?
- What important point does it make or support?

Here is an example of an effective introduction for the line graph shown earlier (Figure 21.4):

Note the sharp increase between 1990 and 2002 in federal spending for disadvantaged children (see Figure 21.4), which rose steadily over this period despite fluctuations in partisan control of Congress and the White House.

Placing the Visual in an Appropriate Location. MLA style requires and APA style recommends that you place a visual in the body of your text as soon after the discussion as possible, particularly when the reader will need to consult the visual. In APA style, visuals can also be grouped at the end of an essay if they contain supplemental information that may not be of interest to the reader or if the visuals take up multiple pages. (See Figure 21.13 for a page from a sample student paper with a figure included. Note that the figure is mentioned in the text and placed directly after this introduction, and that it includes a descriptive title with source information.)

Stanford University anchors the reputation and identity of their law school via their Web site (see Figure 1). The page features strongly contrasting colors—red, black, and light grey—and includes graphics that change each time the page is reloaded: photos of students and professors, in class and on campus, as well as questions whose answers are likely to be of interest to prospective students and other visitors to the site. These rotating graphics are meant to represent the various facets of Stanford Law School.

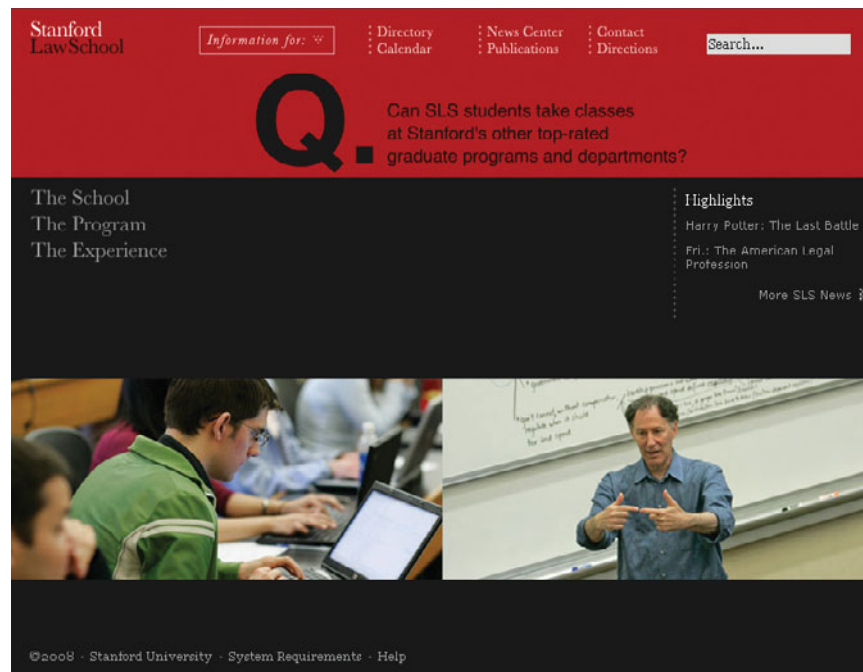


FIGURE 1: Home Page of Stanford Law School (image captured on March 14, 2008 from <http://www.law.stanford.edu>).

The question and photos are the most prominent features of the page, but the basic information about the law school (linked from “The School,” “The Program,” and “The Experience” at left) is easy to locate.

Figure 21.13 Excerpt from Sample Student Paper with Figure

Use Common Sense When Creating Visuals on a Computer

If you use a computer program to create visuals, keep this advice in mind:

- **Make the decisions that your computer cannot make for you.** A computer can automatically turn spreadsheet data into a pie chart or bar graph, but only you can decide which visual — or what use of color, if any — is most appropriate for your purpose.
- **Avoid “chart junk.”** Many computer programs provide an array of special effects that can be used to alter visuals, including three-dimensional renderings, textured backgrounds, and shadowed text. Such special effects often detract from the intended message of the visual by calling attention to themselves instead. Use them sparingly, and only when they emphasize key information.
- **Use clip art sparingly, if at all.** Clip art consists of icons, symbols, and other simple, typically abstract, copyright-free drawings. Because clip art simplifies ideas, it is of limited use in conveying the complex information contained in most academic writing.

Sample Documents

Earlier in this chapter you saw examples of various types of visuals; in this section you will take a look at various types of documents that you may be asked to prepare. Each sample document is accompanied by a discussion of appropriate design conventions.

As you examine the documents, try also to analyze the way that typography, color, white space, and visuals are used to guide the reader’s eye across the page. What design features make the documents easy to read? What features make finding specific information within the documents easy? What features make the document easy to use?

In addition to examining the sample documents with these questions in mind, look at the sample research paper in Chapter 24, pp. 787–94.

Memos

Memos, such as the one shown in Figure 21.14, are documents sent between employees of the same organization (in contrast to business letters, which are sent to people outside the organization). The following conventions for writing a memo are well established and should rarely be altered. In addition, some organizations have specific guidelines for memos (such as the use of letterhead).

- **Heading.** A memo should carry the major heading *Memorandum* or *Memo*. If you are using letterhead stationery, position the heading just below the letterhead. The heading may be centered on the page or positioned at the left margin (depending on your organization’s guidelines). In either case, the heading should be distinguished in some way from the rest of the body text, such as by a large font size, boldface type, or capital letters.
- **Content headings.** Just below the heading and separated by at least one line of space are the content headings: *Date*, *To*, *From*, and *Subject*. Place the content headings at the left margin and in the same size font as the body text.
- **Body text.** The main text of a memo is usually presented in block style: single-spaced with an extra line of space between paragraphs. (Do not indent the first